Science · L7 · Guide

Guide notes: a safe soil test at home

For your parent or guide · 2 pages

What you need

- Three clear plastic bottles, cut in half (the top half upside down as a funnel)
- Cotton cloth or coffee filters
- Three soils: clay, loam, sand (one cup each)
- A measuring jug and a timer

Safety

- An adult does the cutting.
- Wash hands after handling soil.
- Don’t use soil from near latrines or rubbish.

Steps

1. Line each funnel with cloth and add one cup of soil.
2. Pour 200 ml of water into each, at the same time.
3. Wait 10 minutes. Measure the water collected.
4. Repeat the test. Average the results.

What to expect

Soil	Water through	Why
Sand	About 170 ml	Large grains, big gaps
Loam	About 120 ml	Mixed grains
Clay	About 60 ml	Tiny grains, packed close

Questions to ask

- What did you keep the same? What might you have missed?
- Why repeat the test?
- Which soil would you choose for a vegetable garden, and why?

Link to the learner model: a prediction written before the test, and a reason after it, both count as evidence for “Fair tests”.